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POWER PLAY

On rent control, a house divided

Real estate sector can't reach consensus on compromise as deadline approaches

By Jon Chesto
and Shirley Leung
GLOBE STAFF

The local real estate industry is facing the most consequential deci-

sion it may make for a long time: Deal or no deal?

So far there's no consensus among developers, landlords, and real estate agents, as they stare down a July 1 deadline for a com-

promise that would keep what would be one of the nation's strictest rent control policies from reaching the ballot this fall.

That's because the proposed compromise would usher in something industry leaders have long resisted: limits on annual rent increases. They have the money and the motivation to go all the way to

defeat the measure in November, which would ensure it can't be brought back to the voters for another six years.

But sensing that might be too risky of a path, a small faction broke off this spring to work on an alternative that could prompt rent-control supporters to drop the ballot

POWER PLAY, Page A7

Green crabs will ruin the ecosystem . . .



but not if we eat them first

From menace to delicacy

By Sabrina Shankman

GLOBE STAFF



PHOTOS BY CRAIG F. WALKER/GLOBE STAFF

Green crabs that start in Scott Connor's skiff (top) could end up as broth for Mark Sawler in Pembroke.

The Carolina Skiff bounced across the chop in Duxbury Bay as it approached a bright green buoy marking Scott Connor's traps. If his catch from the day before was any indication, there was no need to guess what Connor was about to haul up.

This trap was teeming with a squirming, scuttling mountain of green crabs — an invasive species taking over the Gulf of Maine and destroying habitats.

"These guys are monsters," Connor said with a chuckle, pulling a half-full trap onto the deck and dumping its contents into a gray plastic tote.

The crabs, with green, brown, and red carapaces 2 to 4 inches wide, scuttled over each other in a surging pile of constant motion. A few lucky ones landed in a nearby bait container, skittering among shining mackerel, ignorant of the fate they'd soon meet.

INVASIVE SPECIES, Page A10

Artificial wetland seeds vision for lush habitat

By Jaden Perry

GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Lush wetland habitats once lined the Fort Point Channel, the narrow waterway that flows under the Summer Street Bridge. Native species thrived in and around the then-marshy waterway. But the habitat was destroyed in the 1830s when the city lined the channel with stone seawalls to allow for infill to help expand Boston's footprint.

Now, there is a desire to restore that natural habitat, both to bring back some natural beauty to a largely commercial area and also to help bolster climate resilience.

Those granite stones are too large and too expensive to move.



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Wetland habitats in Fort Point Channel were destroyed in the 1830s. A new floating wetland aims to restore ecosystems.

So to restore those crucial ecosystems, harbor advocates and ecologists turned their attention to the top of the water. Last month, a team installed a floating wetland on Fort Point Channel.

Right now, it's not much to look at: a floating patch of mud speckled with green seedlings. But it's loaded with all the needed materials to nurture a self-sustaining wetland habitat. Those seedlings, planted by staff at Save The Harbor, are expected to flourish into a mix of native plant species that will support native wildlife.

"It's important that we have ... islands of ecological coher-

WETLANDS, Page A10

Staffers filed ballot papers for candidates

Mix of political and public work raises legal questions

By Chris Van Buskirk

GLOBE STAFF

Over the course of several weeks this spring, at least seven public employees working under Secretary of State William F. Galvin popped into city or town halls on weekdays to file paperwork to help get the eight-term incumbent back on the ballot.

For House Speaker Ron Mariano, it was his chief of staff who helped handle the political task; for state Auditor Diana DiZogio, an intern in her taxpayer-funded office chipped in. Four aides to Attorney General Andrea Campbell, including her office's top communications official, submitted documents to help ensure she could run for reelection.

The campaign work, their offices said, was all within legal bounds: Their employees used their own vacation, personal, or comp time to help their elected bosses, oftentimes when they would otherwise be working their taxpayer-funded jobs. Several elected officials said they did not ask the employees to help, nor was the campaign work required as part of their official duties.

But public employees' decision to pitch in on their bosses' reelection campaigns can create a delicate dance to avoid illegally mixing political and public work. And staff performing the campaign tasks can nonetheless create uncomfortable optics for the elected officials, according to political watchers.

"It feels a bit off to have your employees helping you get set up for your next campaign," said Ray La Raja, the co-director of the UMass-Amherst Poll. "First, because I wonder about how voluntary it is if that's your boss. And second, it just seems a bit of a conflict of interest for the person doing it — because they're going to benefit directly from their boss staying in power."

The Globe reviewed so-called nomination papers.
NOMINATION PAPERS, Page A6

US shifts focus on grants that aid humanities

National Endowment now aligns with Trump's agenda

By Julian E.J. Sorapuru

GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — During the final days of the Biden administration, the National Endowment for the Humanities awarded \$23 million toward 219 projects. Under President Trump this year, the agency awarded \$75 million to just 84 projects.

The grant-making shift, both in volume and dollar amount, is one of many changes the Trump administration has made to the federal humanities endowment.

Long-criticized by conservatives for funding projects reflective of liberal sensibilities, the endowment has also undergone a cultural transformation over the last year and a half, transforming into a vehicle to amplify the president's cultural agenda.

The Massachusetts Historical Society, for example, was awarded endowment grants in both 2025 and 2026. The society's project last year was approved for \$190,000 — a grant amount close to the NEH average — to train K-12 educators on teaching an inclusive narrative about the American Revolution, featuring the stories of Black and Indigenous people and women.

This year however, the society received a whopping \$3 million from the NEH for a more traditional history proposal: to prepare the personal papers of Founding Father John Adams for publication.

HUMANITIES, Page A7

Rays in airy zone, aah

Monday: Sun returns, cooler. High 70-75, low 57-62.

Tuesday: More sun, mercury. High 84-89, low 63-68.

Weather and comics, **D4-5.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

Tony Awards

"Schmigadoon!," an adaptation of an Apple TV series that gently mocks big, brassy Broadway shows, won for best new musical. Creator Cinco Paul (right) won for the score and the book. **B6.**



THEO WARGO/GETTY IMAGES

Iran and Israel exchanged missiles, imperiling a fragile truce. **A3.**

Officials and victim advocates revealed safety plans tied to upcoming World Cup games. **B1.**

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